

ASHALAYAM

Dream Home for Street Children

Peter Ki

Akash Kumar (11), a class four student, wants to serve the country when he grows up. Nothing unusual here except that, not so long ago, Akash used to be on the platforms of New Delhi railway station. Now he stays at Don Bosco Ashalayam and attends the prestigious Don Bosco Hr. Sec. School at Alaknanda. Thanks to Ashalayam, many children on the streets of Delhi are beginning to realize that they, too, have a future.

And that is just the first step of this magical dream! **Pankaj Kumar Bharti** (17), studies in class eleven. A good dancer, he says, "I dream of becoming a professional dancer." He was also a member of his school's Throwball team which won first prize in 2007 and 2009 and second prize in 2008 in tournaments held in Bhopal. Another student, **Harsharan Singh** (15), wants to become a teacher when he grows up.

Shawaj (13) is so grateful, he is determined to serve in Ashalayam itself once he has made something of himself. Sonu Singh (14), in class nine, is interested in becoming a school Physical Training Instructor.



This is their home - Children of Ashalayam, New Delhi (Photo by: Peter Ki Maram)

Home of Hope – Home of realized dreams

From the railway platform to one of the top schools of New Delhi – Parents who have tried to admit their children in Don Bosco Alaknanda will appreciate this giant leap for a destitute child. This is made possible because Don Bosco is a network and cares for children from all strata of society.

Ashalayam shelters children in need of care and protection. 120 boys are

lodged here and attend various schools in the city. The only condition to get into this 'Home of Hope' is to be a child with very special needs. The inmates are mostly kids who have run away from home, living in railway stations, bus stands, streets and slums; children from broken families; refugees; and marginalized children. (Girls have a home of their own – Auxilium Snehalaya, located next door.)

It's a process

Children on the streets and railway stations enjoy total freedom and, despite some unpleasant experiences, they like it. They do not easily accept the discipline of a regular school. They have to be weaned off their street life.

In the first step, the staff of Asha

alayam befriend the children where they are – the streets. In the second step, they are invited to a temporary night shelter in a little facility set up in the compound of Don Bosco Technical Institute, Okhla – another link in the network of Don Bosco. Here they find food and lodg-



They learn at ease – a guide to help them when they need – children of Ashalayam. (Photo by: Peter Ki Maram)

ing. They have fewer learning experiences and maximum of freedom. At the third stage, when the children have got used to some level of discipline, they move to Ashalayam.

All this is done in consultation with the Child Welfare Committee as per the Juvenile Justice Act.

Once in Ashalayam, children prepare to enter a regular school through a special course of non-formal education. Eventually, they join nearby schools, government or private – several of them in Don Bosco Alaknanda.

Where formal education in schools is not feasible, the youngsters receive

vocational training. Those who are capable of it do an ITI course like the four in Don Bosco Technical institute at Okhla. Others do non-formal courses like those in Don Bosco Youth Centre at Najafgarh – yet another link in this beautifully choreographed network for children and youth. The rest go to other vocational training centres.

Success

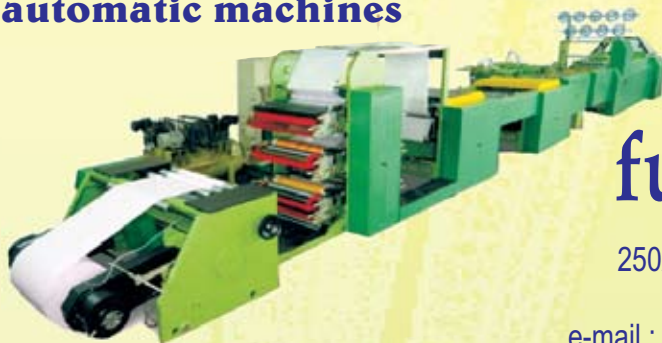
Fr George Nadackal, the director, introduces some of the dreamers under his care. **Jai Shankar** who joined Ashalayam in 1999 is today the manager of the housekeeping section of the Grand Hyatt in Dubai. **Shiv Kumar**, who was picked up from New Delhi railway station is an employee of an NGO (Humana People to People) – and these are just two of the many dreams fulfilled.

Records show that over 4000 children and youth have so far been enabled to dream dreams and get them realized through Ashalayam's street contact, shelter, non-formal education and vocational programmes.



No more running away – children at Ashalayam, showing off their skills in reading (Photo by: Peter Ki Maram)

**Quality EXERCISE NOTE BOOKS
of all varieties with fully
automatic machines**



future educare (p) Ltd

250A G. T. Road Liluah - Howrah 711204 - KOLKATA (WB)

Phone : 2655 3155, Fax : (033) 2655 6679

e-mail : mail@futuremail.in, Website : www.futureeducare.com



Build your School Library

future.

Publishers, Distributors & Wholesaler of School and Children Books

250A, G. T. Road, Liluah - Howrah - 711204 (Kolkata - WB)

Phone : 26554770, Fax : (033) 26556679

email : info@futuremail.in, Visit us : www.futurebooks.in

Consistent follow-up, says Fr. Edward Sacrawat, the deputy director, is the key. Following Don Bosco's preventive system, the children are encouraged to pursue their hobbies of interest: from music and dancing to computers and sports. During holidays, camps are organized. Skits and cultural programmes motivate them to develop their talents. A full-time staff nurse, Marykutty James, takes care of the children's health.

Slum schools

Not content with all this, Ashalayam also conducts classes in six places in the city – in slums, under trees in parks and near the railway tracks. A totally new facility is under construction in Passor, just across the state borders in Haryana's Jajhar district. It will accommodate more of such children in need.

The priority is, of course, the repatriation of run-away kids back to their own families, whenever that is possible, again, in collaboration with the Child Welfare Committee.

Ashalayam serves as the nodal agency of 'Childline' for West Delhi. Ashalayam also hosts the office of the national co-ordination of Don Bosco's work for street children and child labour in 92 towns across India. All of this weaves, indeed, into a dreamland the underprivileged children of this great nation are invited to step into.



Slum children and children of migrants attend classes at one of six non-formal centres of Ashalayam in parks and other public places.

(Photo by: Peter Ki Maram)

For more information, log on to <http://www.dbasha.org>

To support the work of Ashalayam, Delhi, send your donations to: Don Bosco Ashalayam, Palam Gaon, New Delhi – 110 045

To support similar work for street children/Child labourers in any of 92 towns in India, send your MO/cheque/DD/Direct Deposit to: BOSCONET, Acc No. 15450100015254 in The Federal Bank Limited, Dwarka Branch, New Delhi 110 075. (IFSC: 000FDRL1545)

OR

BOSCONET, Acc No. 0359053000013067 in The South Indian Bank Limited, Janakpuri Branch, New Delhi (IFSC: SIBL0000359)